East Bengal club, followed by Mohammedan Sporting (Rs 5.56 crore) and Mohun Bagan (Rs 5.38 crore) between 2011 and 2021. Members of all three clubs accompanied her to Spain in September where, amid investment meets, Mamata met Javier Tebas, the president of La Liga, in Madrid. The Bengal government signed a memorandum of understanding with La Liga to develop the game in the state. A similar initiative by the Left Front government—to tie up with FC Bayern Munich to start a football academy in Burdwan—in 2008 had come to nothing.



THROW IN
TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee with a club's players during a football tournament in Kolkata

A FAMILY AFFAIR

Some of Mamata's relatives and top TMC leaders are now installed as top officials in governing bodies like the Indian Football Association (IFA), which runs the game in Bengal. Brother Ajit Banerjee, for instance, is the current IFA president; Swarup Biswas, brother of sports minister Aroop Biswas, is one of Ajit's three deputies. Ajit is also a special invitee to the executive committee of East Bengal. Two state ministers, Aroop and Moloy Ghatak, and TMC state general secretary Kunal Ghosh are among the four vice-presidents of Mohun Bagan. Another brother of Mamata, Swapan Banerjee, is the club's football secretary. However, the TMC dismisses all criticism that the football connections of its leaders are nothing but 'hypocrisy'. The party cites the appointment of Jay Shah—son of Union home minister Amit Shah—as secretary of the Board of Control for Cricket in India, and of Kalyan Choubey—former Indian footballer and BJP leader—at the helm of the AIFF (All India Football Federation). "What are Jay Shah and Kalyan Choubey's contributions? Yet they hold key roles in the BCCI and AIFF," says Kunal Ghosh. "As for me or Ajit Banerjee or Swapan Banerjee...we have been associated with football all our lives."

However, it is not just key official posts that TMC leaders are at the helm of. Club football's powerful hold over an area, and its possible use to maintain political clout, has also prompted



"What are Jay Shah and Kalyan Choubey's contributions? Yet they hold key roles in BCCI and AIFF. As for me, Ajit or Swapan Banerjee...we have been associated with football all our lives"

KUNAL GHOSH
Trinamool Congress state general secretary

top party leaders, starting from Mamata's nephew and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, to have football teams of their own. Abhishek runs the Diamond Harbour FC, which is now playing the premier division—the highest category—of the CFL (Calcutta Football League). Ajit and Swapan run two teams called the Kalighat Milan Sangha and the Kalighat Football Lover's Association respectively. Aroop owns Suruchi Sangha and his cabinet colleague Sujit Bose runs the Sribhumi Sporting Club. The Belgharia Athletic Club is run by TMC MLA Madan Mitra. Diamond Harbour FC and Belgharia Athletic got affiliated to the first division of the CFL in 2021-2022 by paying a hefty fee of Rs 15 lakh. According to CFL rules, it isn't illegal to buy into the first division, but doing so had long gone out of practice.

PLAYING POLITICS

A TMC leader admits that football matches serve as prime platforms for social outreach at the grassroots. "Some matches pull more crowds than political rallies," he tells INDIA TODAY. "The youth of Bengal love football and they will love you if you present them with a good tournament." No piffling affairs, players at these tournaments are paid handsomely, depending on their performances. According to Snehasish Dutta, a footballer with the Aryan football club and a regular at the local circuit, initial remuneration starts from Rs 2,000 a match and can go up to Rs 10,000-Rs 15,000. "It depends on how we are performing. A player is revered if he has performed well in official tournaments like the CFL or the IFA Shield," he claims.

Some patrons walk an extra mile